



Gadkari has failed to get support from many national leaders, who still view him as a regional politician. They are waiting for him to fail as that would mean the failure of the RSS.

Maharashtra associates, including now party treasurer Piyush Goel and secretary Kirit Somaiya. He is also believed to have exercised some influence in his choice of selecting some state presidents including Vijendra Gupta for Delhi and Surya Pratap Shahi for Uttar Pradesh. The decisions revived the old fault lines with a vengeance. Vijay Goel, who had taken for granted that he would be the next Delhi unit chief, was left fuming. So was Rajnath Singh, who wanted the RSS to oppose the appointment of Shahi for Uttar Pradesh.

It is the 'Delhi Four'—Jaitley, Swaraj, Kumar and Venkaiah Naidu—

who are believed to be blocking the re-entry of Jaswant Singh into the party. It is these four, who also effectively blocked the return of Uma Bharti too. The others in the party are waiting for Gadkari to assert himself, and see if there is any truth in the oft-repeated description as "his own man, who does not allow anyone to dictate terms to him". At the same time, there are others in the party who view RSS influence as detrimental to the BJP. They are the ones who are waiting and watching, hoping that Gadkari falters and fails because it will indirectly be the failure of the Sangh.

At present, he appears to have allowed himself to be manipulated. A member of the party's national executive, close to Gadkari, says that the laid-back attitude is intentional. "The party is seeing the period of 2010-2012 as not too relevant. These are the years where the Advani era is being allowed to run out and then the next will begin. Then one will see the Gadkari-effect on the party when the influence of some of the leaders, considered to be a baggage by the RSS, will cease," says an aide.

Gadkari's political adviser and RSS ideologue Vinay Sahasrabudhe also feels that there is a need for the party to follow and cultivate its distinctive persona. "Every individual and party has a persona which cannot be changed and should not be tampered with," he says. According to him, Gadkari has touched upon certain things which had been forgotten by the party. These include social entrepreneurship and *Antyodaya*, as part of which, each and every party functionary will spend some time doing social service. The result of these things is not instant and takes time, he adds. However, what will happen after two years is just a matter of speculation. Now, six months down the line, Gadkari's performance has been rated as below average. "When he took over as the party chief, Gadkari had spoken about a performance audit. Going by that, his performance is not even worth rating yet," says a party leader. "He has his good points. He is honest, straightforward, transparent and well meaning. He has a vision for the future. The problem is in implementation. Just like *Sheikh Chilli*," he adds. ■

watches from the sidelines, there are others who remain important



Ananth Kumar

Gadkari relies heavily on his advice due to which Kumar has emerged as a key player in his team.



Sushma Swaraj

She positions herself as the moderate face of the party, modelling herself on the lines of Atal Bihari Vajpayee.